

# PART ONE

## Becoming a Millionaire

HOW I MADE MY FIRST

BILLION

Though this book is not an autobiography, the views I express in it are my own and have grown out of my life experience. I think, therefore, that a brief description of my career might be of interest to the reader. If I have a business "philosophy," it was formed in the oil fields and elsewhere in the oil industry.

After many fruitless months of prospecting for oil in Oklahoma, I finally spudded my first test well not far from Stone Bluff, a tiny Muskogee County hamlet, in early January 1916.

On February 2, the bailer—the device which cleared formation rock from the drill hole—brought up a quantity of oil sand. This indicated that we were nearing the final

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stages of drilling; the next 24 hours would prove whether the well was a producer or a dry hole.

I was still very young and quite green. My nervousness and excitement rose to an intolerable pitch. I became more hindrance than help to the men on my drilling crew. To get out of their way and ease my own tension, I beat a strategic retreat to Tulsa, the nearest city of any size. I decided to wait there until the drilling operation was completed and the results were known. In Tulsa, J. Carl Smith, a close friend who was considerably older and far less excitable than I, volunteered to go to the drilling site and supervise the work there for me.